was a red flag and a storm weathered, but all of it sat within the side, like the slow first cracks across a glacier. In a packed schedule, with back-to-back Ashes for some reason meaning we are straight over to Australia, the ice suddenly races its way through beneath our footing, breaking where we stand, separating us as islands, then falling into the sea.

Of all the places it had to implode too, it had to be Australia. There are tiny, symbolic things that send a superstitious shudder; Michael Carberry's bat breaks, playing a perfect forward defensive, for example. But there are bigger chasms too, inside and out. Mitchell Johnson, excitedly waved off by the Barmy Army on the last Ashes trip, a song invented just for his erratic bowling, has come back with a point to prove. He wears a handlebar moustache – like he's been given one handed down by the Australian greats, making him seem like an ancient Australian Pom-bashing relic made new. Since the summer, he has found extra pace which, even from afar, is making standing in front of him seem like a terrifying experience. Ian Bell walks back after the first Test, telling the dressing room that he was too quick for him. Kevin Pietersen does the same, getting back into the dressing room and saying how quick it felt to face him. We all glance at each other, unsure how to process that he of all people has just said that. If it's too quick for him, what chance do we have then?

I'm out in the middle and Michael Clarke is spitting venom, relishing having an exponent to wreak some revenge and havoc for his country. While I stand there, showing with every ounce of my being that I won't back away, he says, 'Get ready for a broken fucking arm.' It's not the only thing that is said, but it's picked up by stump mics and repeated forever. Off the pitch, the negativity threatens to take over, affecting each player in turn. Swann is told off in the dressing room for not taking batting seriously, for not wanting to face Johnson. Broady is being made a target wherever he goes – his not walking during the summer just gone turning him into a pantomime villain – newspapers refusing to use his face or show his name. Jonathan Trott, too, has been going through internal demons, and sitting at breakfast before the first Test, Broady and I see him walk past in tears. Trotty's an amazing man, in so many ways the centre point of what the team stands for, and as he leaves the tour for personal reasons, he takes the soul of the side with him.